

Impact High · Difficulty Easy-Medium · Misuse risk A sceptical, courtroom tone turns "How so?" into a demand for proof, so t

THE MOVE

You said the second option feels safer. How so? -> You are worried the launch will slip. How do you see that happening? -> You said the tone felt different. How did it come across? -> You think the client is not ready. How are you reading that? -> Y...

START HERE

When a person says something compressed, ask one warm, neutral "How so?" and then stop talking.

SAY THIS

Neutral everyday	<i>"How so?"</i>
Work and decisions	<i>"How do you see that playing out?"</i>
Digital / asynchronous	<i>"Can you say how you are reading that?"</i>
Warm personal	<i>"How has that been for you?"</i>
Pressure and disagree...	<i>"I want to understand before I respond. How so?"</i>
Softeners when trust...	<i>"I may not have the full picture — how so?"</i>

AVOID

- The person is in acute distress and needs support, not elaboration
- They have already explained and you would only be repeating the prompt
- The answer is obvious and the question would feel performative

REMEMBER

Put a cushion before "How so?" when the stakes are high.